

Feeling way more homesick than you expected

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

For anyone who just moved out for the first time, quietly sure this means they aren't cut out to be on their own. It's easier to blame yourself than admit you're just struggling right now.

THE GOAL

You're trying to stop treating how homesick you feel as proof you don't belong, and get through it without drowning in it or burying it.

CHECKLIST

You're alone, it's quiet, and the ache of missing home hits hard right now.

- ☐ Put your phone face down or close your laptop for a minute instead of scrolling through the feeling in the background.
- ☐ If one specific thing set this off, a message, a song, a smell, say it out loud or type it in one line.
- ☐ **Set a timer** for ten minutes before you do anything else about it.
- ☐ After sitting with it a few minutes, get up and change something physical: open a window, get water, or sit somewhere else.
- ☐ Say out loud or type which is true right now: hear someone from home, find people here, or stay alone longer.
- ☐ If you call someone from home, keep it simple: "just wanted to hear your voice for a minute."
- ☐ If you want people here, go to wherever they already are, a common room or a friend's open door.
- ☐ If you'd rather stay alone, pick one small task to do anyway, like getting tomorrow's clothes ready or answering one message.
- ☐ If part of this is doubt about picking the wrong place, **write that one worry down** instead of deciding anything about it tonight.
- ☐ If your parents ever promised to come get you, don't decide anything tonight: put a specific day on the calendar to talk it over later.
- ☐ Before you go back to what you paused, pick the exact point to resume from, not just "get back to it."
- ☐ If you're up for one more step, message or wave at one person here you haven't talked to yet today.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** How rough this feels depends less on how bad your week is than on **how hard you're being on yourself**.
- 2** How sure you feel that you picked the wrong place can move with how satisfied you feel with your social life overall, especially if you're hard on yourself about it. A first-year study found the link was strongest for the students hardest on themselves.
- 3** Don't lean on a standing "come get you" promise for safety; keeping it open keeps missing home in your mind.

What's actually driving this

KNOW

How rough this feels depends less on how bad your week is than on **how hard you're being on yourself**.

Treating yourself kindly under stress, the way you would a friend, cushions the blow so a bad week doesn't spiral into feeling homesick. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

How sure you feel that you picked the wrong place can move with how satisfied you feel with your social life overall, especially if you're hard on yourself about it. A first-year study found the link was strongest for the students hardest on themselves.

Doubt about your decision moves with how satisfied you feel about your social life right now, not with the decision itself. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Don't lean on a standing "come get you" promise for safety; keeping it open keeps missing home in your mind.

An open exit keeps you weighing whether to use it instead of settling into where you are. [Source 4](#)

What's actually normal

KNOW

You're not the exception here. A tracked study found 94 percent of first-year students felt homesick at some point in just their first ten weeks away, and only 6 percent never did.

Even the 174 students who filled out a weekly check-in for ten weeks almost all had **at least one homesick week**. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

For most people, the ache eases within a handful of weeks after leaving, though rarely in a smooth downward line.

So a bad week here or there doesn't mean it's getting worse for good, it's normal for the dip to be uneven. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

There's no fixed percentage of homesick people to measure yourself against. Estimates vary hugely depending on where and how people are asked, but every version finds large numbers of people affected.

Comparing your own experience to a specific number you saw somewhere is comparing it to a moving target. [Source 3](#)

What connecting here actually does

DO

Build a real connection in your new place early: feeling at home there tracks with less intense homesickness.

Feeling connected where you are competes directly with the pull of missing where you were. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

A study that tracked students weekly found feeling homesick went with weaker new relationships at college, while relationships with people back home held up fine, if anything a little stronger.

Leaning on people you already trust doesn't come at the cost of the home relationships you're worried about losing. [Source 2](#)

Sources

1. <https://self-compassion.org/wp-content/uploads/publications/Homesickness.pdf>
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5280212/>
3. https://pure.rug.nl/ws/files/87063970/Homesickness_A_systematic_review_of_the_scientific_literature.pdf
4. https://drchristhurber.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/06/HS-in-University_JACH_2012-1.pdf

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Leaving home at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)